

**To:** Qualitative Coding Assignment

**From:** Ray Wagoner

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**Subject:** Leroy's Transcript

**Synthesis of Journal:**

This was an interesting exercise. I learned a lot about coding and extracting themes from a transcript. I needed to wrap my head around the whole interview process, so my first pass was to follow the questions and responses to make sense of the whole. I wrote notes about what the researcher and co-researcher might be trying to accomplish. I then used in vivo coding to assign words from the transcript to each section where the co-researcher replied. My partner, Todd, and I met to discuss the process and our ideas for codes. Once we decided to create a document in Teams to comment on, we re-coded it so that each of us could read the others' code. During class, the process of extracting themes was clarified, and Todd and I decided to work separately again at first. We met once again to collaborate on our individually created themes. As we both had created similar themes, we chose to use Todd's themes as stated, with one exception. We chose this because they were written in full sentences and more fully articulated the heart of the co-researcher's answers. The one exception to Todd's list was deciding to combine numbers two and five. These two themes were identical, just with different words, so we combined the sentence into a single sentence that included all the words. I feel confident from this experience that I can generalize coding in a larger research project with ongoing feedback from a more seasoned researcher.

**Themes:**

- Pastors carry a heavy emotional weight and spiritual responsibility
- Pastors need emotional, mental, spiritual, and family wellness

- Pastors need to develop clear professional boundaries and work balance
- Pastors need to resist the urge to be reactive and respond with thoughtfulness and intentionality

## **First read**

- It's difficult for me to read this with a coding lens right now. I am stuck in learning how the researchers are asking questions and how the process is actually going.
- This first read is going to be emotional for me. I am already connecting to the experiences being described.
- I want to stop reading here and print out the transcript so I can make more notes.
- Okay, reading with the transcript in hand is helpful. I can get a sense of the dialogue and the purpose of the interview.
- I sense a lot of emotional tug of war here and sense the interviewer trying to explore emotion but the co-researcher trying to stay regulated, or protect, or cope by staying more neutral.
- At one point I found myself influenced by Dr. B's comment about the co-researcher deflecting. So, I'm not sure if I'm reading deflection into the script, or if I'm sensing that "in between the words". I love that phrase by the way! I'm going to use that gift from Dr. B. a lot!
- I am pausing the reading here. I got to a point where the dialogue was about the co-researcher's relationship with Jesus and it made me miss Him. So I paused to see what he was up to in my life this morning and to reflect on the world around me. I'm feeling overwhelmed by reading this transcript in the middle of a few other responsibilities. So I'm going to come back to it later today.

- I also want to say that there are many emotions coming up as I read through this. Like I said, I have been a pastor, and I am reading this person's experience as if it were mine. The idea that naps are beneficial because he was physically tired triggered me to remember how I took naps on Sundays. I would have said the same thing back then. I now realize that I was coping/protecting from the overwhelm of Sunday ministry. I missed out on a lot of life with my family on Sundays because of this. I feel both sad and anxious as I reflect on that.
- So, as I finish my first read, I do see the defensive posture of the co-researcher. Not defensive as in taking counter blows, but hiding behind his role, his ministry, the expectations to have it all together.
- Its refreshing to see that we can ask off the cuff questions as the interviewer. Many of the questions were clarifying and contextual questions. The second interviewer popped in finally and circled back to the plan and the purpose, but in the end they still clarified and contextualized.
- I found myself jealous of the co-researcher. I wish that someone had offered me the same kind of emotional support that his wife offers him. I wonder what my ministry journey would have looked like if I could have avoided negative coping patterns. But then I may not be sitting here in this chair working on my PhD and working in the best job I've ever had as a counselor educator.
- The next step of identifying some codes is making more sense now. I have a feel for the dialogue and content. I can see where codes will come from and how to categorize the responses. I will need to go refresh on the rationale and structure for coding and get back to the script.

## Coding

- 11/4/25 – I read through the transcript again and chose words that described Leroy's responses. I went through each response section and tried to identify the main idea or theme of each response. At first, this was a little tricky, but then, the dialogue started supplying the words (I've just learned that this is called in vivo/verbatim coding). Also, I was overthinking at first, then I just settled into what felt right and chose a word.
- Right after this Todd and I met via Teams to try and combine our codes. When Todd talked through his codes, they seemed more like phrases or an overall sense of the response (I've just learned that this is open coding). We decided that our categories and themes would be easier to agree upon than codes. So we decided to upload the document to a Teams folder and make comments with our codes for each response section. That is the next task.
- From class – Dr. B says if we are doing in vivo, then the next step is interpretation because the verbatim words are not interpretation. We do not need consensus on the codes; we just need consensus on the themes.
  - It's okay that the follow-up questions are representative of the themes.

## Themes

- Todd and I worked separately to determine how the codes could be worded more concisely as categories/themes.
- Once we had decided on phrases separately to describe the codes, we shared them with one another.
- My themes were:
  - Pastors hold weight
  - Pastors need healthy minds

- Pastors need rhythm in boundaries
  - Pastors cannot react to crisis
  - Pastors put themselves last
- Todds Themes were:
  - Pastors carry a heavy emotional weight and spiritual responsibility
  - Pastors need emotional, mental, and spiritual wellness
  - Pastors need to develop clear professional boundaries and work balance
  - Pastors need to resist the urge to be reactive and respond with thoughtfulness and intentionality
  - Pastors must prioritize self-care and family well-being
- During class, I heard different ways of coming to a consensus. But It appears that Todd and I are on the same page.
- I heard in class that epistemology impacts our phrasing and word choice. If this is true, then apparently Todd and I are on the same epistemological page.
- I heard in class that it is not always easy to determine the consensus. I wonder —and this is a risk to say, as I submit a journal/memo for a grade —but whether we are being overly agreeable to get along, not prolong the process, and complete it in time. I wonder if a different project would carry more epistemological weight and therefore be more restrictive in the language I would be willing to use?
- I heard in class that there is no one right way to do this. What is important is communication. Perhaps I could even connect it to systems thinking again and say that it is meta-processing as we go.
- My experience in class is that I must be a qualitative researcher. It's neither complex nor laborious for me to code and process themes. I enjoy thinking through people's stories in this manner.

## **Collaborating**

- Todd and I met again for one last sweep of the transcript. We decided that we agreed on the full sentence themes that Todd created. We agreed that they covered what I had created and what Todd had created equally.
- Our combined themes are:
  - Pastors carry a heavy emotional weight and spiritual responsibility
  - Pastors need emotional, mental, spiritual, and family wellness
  - Pastors need to develop clear professional boundaries and work balance
  - Pastors need to resist the urge to be reactive and respond with thoughtfulness and intentionality
  - ~~Pastors must prioritize self-care and family well-being~~
- We choose to combine number 2 and number 5 as they were covering the same theme with different people and from sections of the transcript.
- This was an interesting effort. Again, I felt passionate about this subject, but not passionate enough to differ on any point from Todd.
- We also discussed how we could see the themes and patterns from our training in sermon preparation.
- Overall, I am satisfied with the outcome and, although I know that adding co-researchers would clarify themes, I feel we reached saturation with this transcript. This is a question I asked Todd and he concurred.